

Korea Daily Brief

Tuesday, September 29, 2026

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RE: DMZ mine confirmed NK origin · NK POW handover row deepens · Zelensky warns 10K new NK troops · ROK cabinet passes nuclear sub bill

KOSPI
6,870.81
▼ -0.3%

USD/KRW
1,355.06
▲ +0.0%

BRENT
\$97.30
▼ -7.6%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 ROK-Ukraine ties strain as Seoul summoned Kyiv's envoy to demand an apology after President Zelensky publicly revealed North Korean POWs had been transferred to South Korea without prior disclosure.
- 2 A joint ROK-UNC on-site probe found a North Korean resin anti-personnel mine near the Sep 21 DMZ blast site; Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul called the blast a 'clear' armistice violation and linked the mines to Pyongyang's border reinforcement work.
- 3 Zelensky warned Russia is preparing to deploy an additional 10,000 North Korean troops — adding to over 8,000 already present — and said Moscow has helped Pyongyang establish attack drone manufacturing in exchange for military assistance.

• TOP STORIES

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

Zelensky warns Russia preparing to deploy additional 10,000 North Korean troops; Moscow helped Pyongyang build attack drone factories

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said Monday that North Korea is preparing to send approximately 10,000 more soldiers to Russia, adding to a current contingent of over 8,000 already deployed. Zelensky separately asserted that Russia has helped Pyongyang establish attack drone manufacturing capabilities in exchange for the military assistance. Concurrently, Russian President Putin ordered an army expansion, underscoring the scale of the bilateral military buildup.

NK News · Reuters · CNBC, Sep 29

DPRK

ROK-UNC joint probe finds North Korean resin mine at DMZ blast site; Defense Minister calls it armistice violation, links mines to border reinforcement

A 30-person joint ROK military and UN Command investigation team on Tuesday found a North Korean resin anti-personnel mine near the site of the Sep 21 DMZ explosion that seriously injured three soldiers during a

route-clearing operation. Defense Minister **Kang Shin-chul** said the mine was buried and linked to Pyongyang's border reinforcement work, calling the blast a 'clear' violation of the armistice agreement and vowing 'corresponding measures.' The mine found today was assessed as different from the mine that caused the actual blast, with further investigation ongoing before a final determination.

NK News · WSJ · Reuters · WaPo · Bloomberg, Sep 29

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

Seoul demands Ukraine apology after Zelensky reveals secret North Korean POW transfer; MOFA cites prior non-disclosure agreement

South Korea summoned Ukraine's charge d'affaires and demanded an apology after President Zelensky publicly disclosed that North Korean prisoners of war had been transferred to South Korea — a move Seoul says violated a prior non-disclosure understanding. The Foreign Ministry stated that a 'clear understanding' existed between Seoul and Kyiv, and the revelation created a diplomatic rupture that generated international attention on the operational details of North Korean troop deployment in Ukraine. The episode, reported by WSJ as a secretive handover now become controversial, is the first confirmed public acknowledgment that North Korean combatants captured in Ukraine have been physically transferred to South Korean custody.

WSJ · AP · WaPo · Reuters, Sep 29

US-KOREA

ROK cabinet passes nuclear-powered submarine special bill; North Korea condemns US support for ROK sub ambitions at UN General Assembly

The South Korean government on Tuesday passed a special bill establishing the legal framework for introducing and operating nuclear-powered submarines. North Korea's Vice Foreign Minister **Kim Son Gyong**, speaking at the UN General Assembly in New York, condemned U.S. support for the ROK submarine program, saying Washington had 'approved and is encouraging Seoul's ambition to possess' nuclear-powered submarines and accused the US of worsening regional instability. The cabinet bill passage and simultaneous DPRK reaction at UNGA mark a coordinated escalation in the ROK nuclear submarine issue.

Yonhap · Reuters · NK News, Sep 29

• OVERNIGHT

DPRK	North Korea uses UN platform to lament 'mutual distrust' and tension in relatively mild speech · Washington Post Tone notably restrained compared to recent 'collective punishment' rhetoric
DPRK	Seoul human rights group: North Korea running secret prison beneath Beijing embassy to interrogate and repatriate defectors · NK News Transitional Justice Working Group report released Tuesday
NK-RUSSIA-CHINA	EU blacklists North Korean Songdowon children's camp, citing Russia's use of facility to indoctrinate Ukrainian children · NK News Follows similar UK move that triggered diplomatic row with Pyongyang

CHINA-KOREA

Two former Chinese soldiers indicted for leaking secrets from South Korean and US military · Yonhap English
Indictments issued in Pyeongtaek, home to Camp Humphreys

TECHNOLOGY

Lee orders officials to accelerate \$589B AI hub plans · Nikkei Korea
Third megaproject review meeting focused on residential and living conditions

TECHNOLOGY

Samsung Group to invest \$1B in AI infrastructure company Helix · Yonhap English
Announced Tuesday; sector: AI data center infrastructure

• STAT OF THE DAY

10,000

Additional NK troops Russia preparing to deploy, per Zelensky

Zelensky's warning of a new 10,000-strong DPRK deployment to Russia comes as NK News reports the current contingent already exceeds 8,000 troops, making the total potential force over 18,000.

NK News / Reuters (Sep 29, 2026)

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

• No appearance (7d since last)

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. North Korea blames US for 'worse crisis' in nuclear order, justifies its arsenal

Via KCNA/Yonhap: DPRK accused the United States of creating a 'worse crisis' in the global nuclear order and reiterated justification for its own nuclear arsenal — part of Vice FM Kim Son Gyong's UNGA address. — KCNA (Yonhap)

2. North Korea says US approval for South Korea's nuclear submarine increases regional instability

Via KCNA/Reuters: DPRK's Vice FM Kim Son Gyong at UNGA condemned US support for South Korea's nuclear-powered submarine ambitions, calling it destabilizing to the Korean Peninsula. — KCNA (Reuters)

3. Senior North Korean diplomat reiterates Pyongyang's nuclear status 'can never be reversed in any circumstances'

Kim Son Gyong at UNGA stated DPRK's nuclear status is irreversible under any circumstances, consistent with Choe Son Hui's Sep 24 blanket nuclear irreversibility declaration. — Yonhap English

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Son Gyong · Vice Foreign Minister

Delivered DPRK's UNGA address, condemning US support for South Korea's nuclear submarine program and declaring DPRK's nuclear status irreversible under any circumstances.

Bottom line: DPRK's UNGA track today was led by Vice FM Kim Son Gyong, who combined blanket nuclear irreversibility declarations with a direct attack on US support for ROK's nuclear submarine program — the same

day Seoul's cabinet passed its nuclear sub bill. Kim Jong Un has not appeared publicly in seven days; watch for Punggye-ri seismic activity and Kim's next confirmed appearance.

• ROK GOVERNMENT

President + Ministries · Tuesday, September 29, 2026

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

Confirms DMZ mine is North Korean, calls blast 'clear' armistice violation

Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul

Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul said the North Korean resin anti-personnel mine found near the Sep 21 DMZ blast site was buried and linked to Pyongyang's border reinforcement work. Kang declared the blast a 'clear' violation of the armistice agreement and vowed corresponding measures if North Korean mines are confirmed responsible.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Summons Ukrainian charge d'affaires over undisclosed NK POW transfer; asserts 'clear understanding' was in place

MOFA spokesperson

The Foreign Ministry said Seoul and Kyiv had a 'clear understanding' on non-disclosure of the North Korean POW transfer prior to President Zelensky's public revelation. MOFA has demanded an apology from Ukraine, and the Ukrainian charge d'affaires was formally summoned.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Orders thorough probe of DMZ mine blast, vows necessary measures

President Lee Jae-myung

President Lee Jae-myung called for a thorough investigation into the DMZ mine explosion that injured three soldiers on Sep 21 and vowed to take necessary measures based on the findings. Cheong Wa Dae separately denied that the timing of the military's on-site inspection was connected to Lee's remarks at the UN General Assembly.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Passes special bill on nuclear-powered submarine introduction and operation

Cabinet (full)

The Cabinet passed legislation establishing the legal framework for the introduction and operation of nuclear-powered submarines, providing the statutory basis for a program already triggering DPRK reaction at UNGA.

Agreement to mandate public disclosure of unsolicited corporate takeover bids

Government-ruling party consultative meeting

The government and the Democratic Party agreed to legislate mandatory disclosure of hostile takeover bids, part of the ongoing Corporate Value-up reform agenda aimed at improving shareholder protection.

• US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium stay at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge (a temporary 10% across-the-board measure) expired July 24, 2026, leaving no single baseline reciprocal rate in place. The Section 301 investigation — launched March 11, 2026 against 16 trading partners including South Korea — is now the primary prospective vehicle for new tariff authority.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now the primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE
next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES		
Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

• BUSINESS & ECONOMY

MACRO • BLOOMBERG KOREA

South Korea's central bank is smart not to kill this boom, Bloomberg argues

Bloomberg commentary argues the Bank of Korea is correct to hold its rate at 2.50% rather than tighten aggressively, as KOSPI slips -0.27% on inflation concerns and oil prices remain elevated at \$97.30/bbl.

TECH · YONHAP ENGLISH

Samsung expects foundry customers to quadruple by 2029

Samsung Electronics said Tuesday the number of its foundry customers is expected to quadruple by 2029, reflecting its bet on AI chip demand expansion as it competes with TSMC.

Samsung Electronics

TECH · YONHAP ENGLISH

SK Hynix to provide up to 50% of R&D costs upfront for partner firms

SK Hynix announced it will expand its partner support program by covering up to half of partner firms' R&D costs upfront, a move to deepen its AI chip supply chain ecosystem.

SK Hynix

• NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

TRILATERAL · CHINA-TRADE · ROK PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

President Lee holds summit with Australian PM on energy and critical minerals cooperation

President Lee Jae-myung met Australia's Prime Minister to expand bilateral cooperation on energy and critical minerals — a sector where both countries are seeking to diversify supply chains away from China.

JAPAN-KOREA · JAPAN-DIPLOMATIC · YONHAP ENGLISH

Chief financial regulators from South Korea and Japan agree on further cooperation

South Korea and Japan's chief financial regulators met Tuesday and agreed to deepen bilateral financial regulatory cooperation, continuing the normalization of bilateral economic ties since 2023.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

37%

▼ 1 pts vs 2026-09-11

Gallup Korea · September 18, 2026

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 37% across 4 readings

RULING
Democratic**39%**OPPOSITION
People Power**25%**

INDEPENDENTS

26%**Gallup Korea Spotlight** September 18, 2026

Presidential Approval — New Low: President Lee Jae-myung's approval rating fell to 37%, a new low, down from 38% the prior week and below his previous low of 42% recorded in August.

• UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

DPRK

NK NEWS

Explainer: Why DMZ land mines are notoriously dangerous and hard to control by both Koreas

NK News analysis details how the DMZ's mine-contaminated terrain — a legacy of the Korean War and subsequent mine-laying by both sides — makes attribution and control extremely difficult; relevant context for ongoing investigation into Sep 21 blast.

BUSINESS

REUTERS KOREA

South Korean exports seen rising for 16th consecutive month on solid AI chip demand

Preliminary data suggest September will mark the 16th straight month of South Korean export growth, driven by AI chip demand; September data release due shortly.

ENERGY

BLOOMBERG KOREA

South Korea to unlock more renewable power with grid overhaul, targeting over 100 GW by 2030

The government plans to more than double renewable capacity to over 100 GW by 2030 through grid reconfiguration, following President Lee's announcement that transmission capacity was raised from 119 GW to 171 GW without new infrastructure.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

MND Spokesperson @MNDSpokesperson

“ROK military and UNC conducted a joint on-site investigation of the Sep 21 DMZ mine blast today. The 30-person team found one North Korean resin anti-personnel mine near the blast site, assessed as different from the mine that caused the actual explosion. Final results will be disclosed transparently.”

Context: The MND post confirms the physical evidence found Tuesday and previews a final public determination, consistent with Defense Minister Kang's simultaneous statements calling the blast an armistice violation.

[View on X →](#)

ROK MND @ROK_MND

“MND and the Korea Aerospace Agency co-hosted the 3rd Future Defense Science and Technology Policy Council space subcommittee on Sep 29, discussing civil-military space launch capability expansion and domestic launch vehicles for defense satellites. Following the August amendment to the Space Development Promotion Act, the Defense Minister now directly approves defense space launches.”

Context: The institutional coordination between MND and the Korea Aerospace Agency on defense space launch authority is a direct follow-on to the August statutory amendment, expanding the defense ministry's independent space launch approval power.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Kim Son Gyong

Vice Foreign Minister, DPRK — UNGA address

“The U.S. has approved and is encouraging Seoul's ambition to possess nuclear-powered submarines, worsening tensions on the Korean Peninsula.”

Analyst: Kim's UNGA statement came the same day the ROK cabinet passed a special nuclear submarine bill, making the dual timing a coordinated kinetic-diplomatic sequence; Kim also reiterated that Pyongyang's nuclear status 'can never be reversed in any circumstances.'

[Source →](#)



Kang Shin-chul

Defense Minister, Republic of Korea

“The DMZ blast is a clear violation of the armistice agreement.”

Analyst: Kang's armistice violation declaration, paired with the physical discovery of a North Korean resin anti-personnel mine at the blast site, sets the legal and rhetorical foundation for Seoul's promised 'corresponding measures.'

[Source →](#)

COMMENTARY

38 NORTH

Signs of Life at New Sinuiju-Dandong Crossing

38 North analysis by Martyn Williams presents commercial satellite imagery showing signs of life at the new Sinuiju-Dandong crossing's customs posts on both sides. The findings align with the ROK Embassy in Beijing's September 21 assessment that the bridge is 70-80% complete and could open around October 6.

NK PRO

North Korea expanding uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon: Imagery

NK Pro Planet Labs imagery analysis finds construction of a new annex to the Yongbyon uranium enrichment building began in mid-September, following Kim Jong Un's public order to exponentially expand the nuclear

weapons stockpile. The expansion follows the IAEA's September 2026 assessment that existing facilities can already produce material for up to four additional warheads annually.

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

38 NORTH / NK PRO · SEP 2026 — SINUIJU-DANDONG CROSSING ACTIVITY; YONGBYON ENRICHMENT EXPANSION

38 North detects signs of life at Sinuiju-Dandong crossing; NK Pro confirms new Yongbyon enrichment annex under construction since mid-September

38 North satellite imagery shows activity at customs posts on both the North Korean and Chinese sides of the new Sinuiju-Dandong crossing, consistent with the ROK Embassy in Beijing's September 21 assessment that the bridge is 70–80% complete. Separately, NK Pro Planet Labs imagery confirms construction of a new annex to the original uranium enrichment building at Yongbyon began in mid-September, following Kim Jong Un's orders to 'exponentially' increase the nuclear stockpile. The dual developments — a new trade corridor nearing completion and an expanding enrichment footprint — mark concurrent infrastructure investment in both economic and weapons dimensions.

→ Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border) · Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

38 North: Signs of Life at New Sinuiju-Dandong Crossing ↗ · NK Pro: North Korea expanding uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

NK Pro Planet Labs imagery confirms construction of a new annex to the original uranium enrichment building began in mid-September 2026, following Kim Jong Un's orders to 'exponentially' increase nuclear stockpile. IAEA confirmed (Sep 9-10, 2026) a new uranium enrichment facility capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running.

imagery as of 2026-09-29

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinpo South Shipyard

NK News satellite imagery (Sep 25-26) confirms new warship construction begun at Chongjin Shipyard (east coast) and Nampho Shipyard (west coast) since early July — dual-coast concurrent construction. Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but still not operational as of May 2025. New submarine construction begun in separate bay.

imagery as of 2026-09-26

ACTIVITY ▲

Punggye-ri Nuclear Test Site

Nov 2025: ROK DIA assessed Tunnel No. 3 is test-ready and a nuclear test can be conducted at any time upon political decision. Site maintained at high readiness since mid-2024. The Sep 9, 2016

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is

fifth nuclear test 10-year anniversary fell earlier this month; post-anniversary period historically carries elevated test risk. CNN/Yonhap reported Sep 18 that nearly 1,400 seismic events have been detected near the site since the 2017 test.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery (Sep 29, 2026) shows signs of activity at customs posts on both the North Korean and Chinese sides of the new crossing. Sep 21, 2026: ROK Embassy in Beijing confirmed the cargo carried by heavy trucks crossing the new Yalu River bridge on Sep 17 consisted of air-conditioning units (HVAC equipment) destined for the customs building, indicating construction is roughly 70-80% complete. Embassy source said the bridge could open approximately one month after building completion following a trial period, with the NK-China diplomatic anniversary (Oct 6) cited as a possible opening date. DPRK national insignia already installed on the North Korean customs building.

imagery as of 2026-09-29

ACTIVITY ▲

Rason SEZ

Sep 21-22, 2026: NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel docked at Rason for the first time since May 2026 — a roughly four-month gap after near-continuous activity in 2024-2025. Nov 2025: Chinese businesspeople re-entry to Rason SEZ expanded. Coal exports through Rason at highest levels in years throughout 2025. Arms export berth also active.

imagery as of 2026-09-22

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail. NK News satellite imagery (Sep 18) shows ongoing upgrades to DPRK urban warfare training facilities consistent with troops rotating back from Russia.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

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